



Small margins: Mirabai Chanu finished an agonising fourth in the women's 49kg event in Paris. The Tokyo 2020 silver medallist ended her attempts just one kilogram short of bronze medallist Surodchana Khambao of Thailand.

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Ghoshal announced his retirement from professional squash in April after a 22-year career.

Anahat Singh and Abhay Singh had breakthrough seasons in 2024. The 16-year-old Anahat won nine PSA Challenger titles during the year, while Abhay clinched his tenth PSA title with the Tuanku Muhriz Trophy in Kuala Lumpur.

In the world of Mixed Martial Arts (MMA), India's Puja Tomar became the first-ever Indian fighter to register a win in the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) after a split-decision victory over Brazil's Rayanne dos Santos in Louisville.

Dricus Du Plessis had a year to remember, claiming the middleweight title with a split-decision win over Sean Strickland in January. The South African retained the title in August, forcing Israel Adesanya into submission with a chokehold.

IN 2025...

The Indian sports bandwagon will carry over from the frenetic Olympic year to a relatively low-key year in 2025. The Indian paddlers will be in action in the WTT Feeder and Contender series during the early part of the year, leading up to the all-important World Table Tennis Championships in Doha in May.

With the Pro Kabaddi League concluding before the start of the new year, kabaddi enthusiasts will be looking forward to the Senior Nationals for the first major kabaddi action of the year. The impasse between the AKFI and the world body must be resolved for India to participate in the home World Cup later in the year. Bajrang's suspension and Vinesh's retirement leave Indian wrestling in need of new heroes, and the younger generation will aim to fill the void with strong performances at the upcoming Asian and World Championships.

The standoff between the IOC and the two world bodies — IBA and World Boxing — puts boxing in a state of limbo ahead of Los Angeles 2028. Indian pugilists will be hoping for a quick resolution and clarity on the LA roster, as well as seeking to put behind their Olympic medal drought by bagging a few at the men's and women's World Championships this year. Anshul Jubli will aim for his first UFC win when he faces Quillan Salkild in a lightweight bout, while Puja Tomar will look to build on a positive 2024 as she prepares to take on Shauna Bannon in a strawweight fight.